

St. Joseph

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Go to Joseph, and do all that he shall say to you. (Gn 41:55)

While the seven years of famine were desolating the land of Egypt, its starving people came to the court of Pharaoh to beg for food. The monarch bade them go to the faithful governor of his palace and do whatever he commanded them. Because Joseph had prophesied to Pharaoh this terrible famine, which was to follow the years of plenty, and had in many ways shown his virtue, the prince loaded this illustrious son of Jacob with royal favors, making him the general steward of his household, the governor of all Egypt, and the keeper of the seal of authority (Gn 41:15-37). "And, he made him go up into his second chariot, the crier proclaiming that all should bow their knee before him" (Gn 41:43). Then he laid on him the care of his people in their need.

In this history, with its many symbolic figures, we find a prophecy of what God's gifts of grace wrought in our holy patriarch St. Joseph. Or we might say the virtues and the achievements of the older Joseph are but the shadow of those we honor in our glorious patron. Such is my confidence in his power with God and the veneration that fills me at the sight of his picture or statue, that the words, "Go to Joseph, and do all that he shall say to you," seem no longer those of the olden king but those of our mother Church. Seeing her children about to perish from material want, or from diseases of body and soul, or even from loss of faith, she bids them in her grief: "Go to St. Joseph."

However this thought appeals to you, I am resolved to try to communicate my own devotion to any of you, my dearly beloved, who will have the goodness to hear me. With this end in view, I wish to talk with you about the virtues and prerogatives of St. Joseph.

"O Mary, I have so often invoked you in the course of my labors and preaching, but never, perhaps, with more confidence than at this moment

when I am moved to reveal to my brothers and sisters my thoughts on the holiness and the privileges of the worthy companion of your sublime destiny. Daring to count on your assistance, I humbly implore it in the name of the most pure and faithful heart of your spouse. Hear me for your joy in the angelic salutation. Heart of Joseph, most pure and most faithful, pray for us."

The Virtues of St. Joseph

In this meditation on the virtues of St. Joseph, we shall not present them in detail and historical sequence. For this we have not the means, since both the gospels and tradition keep an extraordinary and almost absolute silence on the subject. This very silence, however, says the utmost to us and makes our incomparable patron greater in our eyes than many words could do. Surely the one who conceals what he could advantageously make known to the world, who hides marvels most fitted to awaken its admiration, is truly virtuous and worthy of highest esteem. Such a one deserves the eulogy offered to the first Christians by the apostle, "You are dead; and your life is hidden with Christ in God" (Col 3:3). Think, then, of the prodigious matters our saint could have revealed to the world—he who was the intimate confidant of the Virgin Mother of God, the recipient of visits from angels, the foster father of the infant Lord, he who was initiated into the plan of the redemption of the human race. The hidden life of the new Joseph and the silence of the gospels in his regard are, then, proof of his very great holiness, and they make him the more worthy of veneration in that they show him more like to Jesus and Mary. What was said of Jesus during the thirty years while the Holy Family lived obscure and inseparable? Only that he grew in age and wisdom before God and men and that he was submissive to his parents. And what was said of the Virgin of Nazareth? Only that she kept and pondered in her heart all that she saw and heard said of her divine son.

The very same gospels tell us that our immortal patriarch was a just man. This eulogy, though we knew nothing further, suffices to give us the

most exalted idea of him and to console us for the silence of scripture and tradition on this subject. When we reflect on the etymological value of the word "just," it seems like one of those brilliant stars that throw a living light on all about them, and it also recalls that rich coat of varied colors with which Jacob clothed his dear son Joseph. The word "just" comes from the old Latin verb *iustare*, meaning to "adjust" or "put in order." Being "just" before God must mean, therefore, to adjust or order one's thoughts, judgments, desires, words, and actions to the divine will that is the eternal rule of all perfection. In proclaiming the spouse of Mary "just," the Holy Spirit spoke, then, the greatest eulogy, declaring Joseph perfect in every respect. Though we could apply this word to each of his virtues, in particular, let us limit ourselves to a study of his perfection in his purity, his obedience, and his poverty. So perfect is he in these virtues that, if his incomparable spouse is the greatest of all saints, their very queen, St. Joseph is undoubtedly the greatest of all these saints.

St. Joseph excels all by his purity. I believe, with the pious Gerson, preaching of our saint to the Council of Constance, and with several worthy Doctors of the Church, that St. Joseph was sanctified in his mother's womb, as were Jeremiah and John the Baptist, and was then confirmed in grace, though this is not saying that he contracted exemption from all sin.³⁵ I believe, with Suárez, that concupiscence of the flesh was dead in him from his birth, so that he was exempt from this law of the members of which the apostle complained and from those disorderly impulses which humbled the greatest saints (Rom 7:14–25).³⁶ With St. Peter Damien, St. Peter Chrysologus, Hugh of St. Victor, Alcuin, St. Albert the Great, St. Bernardine of Siena, and St. Thomas, I believe that he made in early youth a vow of perpetual chastity. I believe with these same authorities, and with St. Francis de Sales, St. Teresa, and at least 350 other historians and eulogists, that spirit and flesh preserved in him virginal integrity.

Surely it is fitting that this should be so. If Jeremiah had to be purified from original sin shortly after his conception because he was to announce the Messiah; if John the Baptist was accorded this favor because he was actually to point out the Savior; if Jesus Christ wanted the best beloved of his disciples to be a virgin, and his mother as well—

in the man who, passing as the father of Jesus, was to carry the Messiah in his arms.

It is true that Mary espoused Joseph, but she did so under the formal condition that she would remain a virgin and that, in giving each other mutual empire over their hearts, they would not give each other their bodies. The Gospel tells us that they "knew not" each other (Lk 1:34). According to the chancellor Gerson, by this exemplary marriage Joseph was given to Mary as the witness, the protector, the guide, and the spouse of her virginity. What a holy alliance. One virginity is united to another. Here are two creatures in whom the Holy Spirit, the mysterious bond between the Father and the Son in eternity, becomes the conjugal bond in time. Far from Mary and Joseph is every desire, every thought, of flesh and blood; all is pure, all is spiritual. On the one side is, according to St. Denis, the most beautiful creature on whom the sun has shone; she has such majesty on her countenance, such brilliance in her eyes, and so divine an air, that one has almost to force himself from adoring her. On the other is a man disengaged from all the senses, superior to all inclinations of degraded nature, one who lives amid flames but is not burned, who is surrounded by an ocean of lights but is not dazzled, who feels the arrows of the most perfect love but is not wounded. I seem to see the cherubim charged to watch the gate of the terrestrial paradise, or better, the two cherubs of gold who, on the two sides of the oracle, spread their wings and covered the mercy seat to form the throne of the divine majesty above the Ark of the Covenant (Ex 25:18-22).

It is not surprising, after such consideration, to hear a pious commentator, Cornelius a Lapide, cry out that St. Joseph seems rather an angel than a man.³⁷ Nor can we doubt that if, to become the mother of Jesus, Mary had to be the purest of virgins, Joseph had to be the purest of men to become the spouse of Mary and the reputed father of the Savior. If another more just than he in this regard could have been found, that one would have been preferred for so noble a union. Hence, we conclude that the holy patriarch was the most pure, most modest, most chaste among the sons of Adam, and consequently the most perfect in his virginity, which exalted him as much above other saints as the lily excels other flowers by its whiteness.

St. Joseph practiced obedience also in the most perfect manner. While he was enjoying at Nazareth the delights of the most sacred union ever contracted and was practicing all the virtues of the hidden life, heaven heaped on him the worst trials to which the human will can submit. Let us note the dolorous events that came upon his heart as father and spouse. To carry out the command of the emperor Augustus concerning the numbering of his subjects, St. Joseph was obliged to go to Bethlehem, traveling the thirty leagues and crossing steep mountains probably on foot in December, the most inclement season of the year. And he did all this when his virgin spouse was ready to give birth to her child. When they finally arrived in the city, they found all the inns closed against them. The only refuge they could find in the city their ancestors had governed was a cave, which had been hollowed in the rock to serve as a shelter for the flocks. Here began new sufferings for the Holy Family, and especially for St. Joseph, who had the care of Jesus and Mary. Did he let himself complain or even be distressed? Assuredly not. Rather, he makes us admire his resignation to the ruling of providence and his obedience to every trial God asked of him.

The infant God, who came to earth to redeem the world and teach it obedience, wished to fulfill the Jewish law and thus furnish example of this difficult virtue. He was presented in the Temple on the fortieth day after his birth. His blood flowed in the Jewish circumcision. The old man Simeon spoke of the sword of sorrow that would pierce the soul of Mary because of the obedience of Jesus even unto death (Lk 2:34-35). This sword went also into the heart of St. Joseph, even though he was not actually at the passion of Jesus, for the terrible future which was then announced was from that moment present to his mind to afflict his compassionate soul.

Scarcely had the Holy Family settled again in their home when an angel appeared to St. Joseph in a dream to bid him: "Arise, and take the child and his mother, and fly into Egypt; and be there until I shall tell you. For it will come to pass that Herod will seek the child to destroy him" (Mt 2:13). That jealous and angry prince, having seen the Magi come from the Orient to adore at the crib of the newborn king and being fearful for his throne, ordered the massacre of the innocents. It might well have

seemed strange and even bewildering to St. Joseph to be ordered to take such a flight. He might well have asked why the Son of the Most High was obliged to flee before a man, let alone such a man. He might well have questioned why he must go into a distant and unknown country and expose a frail infant to the weariness and perils of such a difficult journey; why he must set forth during the very night when he received the order, without preparation and provisions; why he must take refuge among a people who were idolatrous and avowedly unfriendly to the Jews and live there until it pleased providence to have him return, with no word at all from the angel as to the duration of the exile. These were questions that would naturally arise in such circumstances, at least in the minds of most of us. Could religious obedience offer a more difficult trial? Yet, without a word from Joseph, Mary, or Jesus, the Holy Family obeyed.

So we see that the obedience of our glorious patriarch was not less perfect than his purity. Let us remark on its qualities. It is blind obedience which does not stop to reason about the expediency of the command. Joseph did not allege that he was ignorant of the way to Egypt; that Jesus, still so young, could not endure such a journey; that he could not set out in the night and run such risks on the way; that he could not find means of livelihood when he would reach Egypt; and that, after all, God could save his son from Herod without subjecting his parents to such difficulties. Joseph's obedience is prompt and unhesitating. The Gospel tells us that he arose and took the child and his mother by night and went into Egypt (Mt 2:14). It is generous and constant obedience. Nothing stopped St. Joseph; nothing discouraged him, though it seemed that he lacked everything necessary. But he was sufficiently rich because Jesus and Mary were with him. Even had he lacked this consolation, he would have obeyed unto death, the death of the cross.

It is evident that our incomparable patron surpasses all other saints in his purity and his obedience. He is also the greatest of them all in his love of poverty. Joseph, as well as Mary, was of the tribe of Judah, descended in direct line from David, and hence he was an heir to the throne of Israel. Since he was destined to be the foster father and guardian of Jesus Christ, however, it was fitting that he be poor like the Savior,

and penance, and second, in order to be conformed to his divine son, who had not anywhere to rest his head and who was to proclaim voluntary poverty one of the evangelical beatitudes (Mt 5:6).

Far from trying to reclaim his ancestral crown, therefore, St. Joseph did not even seek to leave his obscure and poor state of life. He, rather, cherished his condition, which was so mean and humiliating in the eyes of the world. Submitting gladly to the decree of eternal justice that condemns us to earn our bread by the sweat of our brow, he lived as a simple artisan, a day workman in wood and iron. Even more, when his angelic spouse gave birth to the Savior, though he suffered to see Jesus born into such woeful misery, he contemplated in silent and perfect resignation the stable that served the little king for a palace, the manger that did for a cradle, the straw that formed his couch, the swaddling clothes that formed the royal mantle, and the animals that warmed Jesus with their breath while they did duty for courtiers.

Could poverty go further? What is the poverty of prophets, apostles, solitaries, and religious in general compared to the destitution we have just seen? Had we not reason to say that, in the praise of St. Joseph by the Holy Spirit, the word "just" is equivalent to the word "perfect"? And is it not right to conclude that, if he surpassed all other saints in purity and obedience, he was also the greatest in poverty, not in mind and in heart alone but in reality? Yes, with no fear of being considered rash, we may conclude that if Mary is queen of all saints through her virtues, through her glory in heaven, and through her privileges on earth, St. Joseph, though assuredly inferior to his celestial spouse, is after her the greatest saint we can honor on earth.

How could it be otherwise? When the adorable Trinity resolved to elevate the Virgin of Nazareth to the highest imaginable dignity, by accomplishing in her womb the mystery of the Incarnation and making her the finest masterpiece of grace after Christ's own humanity, God could only honor her further by making the man destined to share her supreme destiny the most worthy of all men in incomparable holiness. And Mary herself, by consenting to enter into her most holy marriage with Joseph, could but make him a sharer in all the gifts of the Holy Spirit, which she

whatever belonged to the one had to belong to the other. Hence, it follows that there was no sentiment, however noble; no affection, however pure; no faith, however living; no charity, however glowing, in the heart of the Virgin Mother that was not also in the heart of her virgin spouse. This was the reasoning of St. Bernardine of Siena, and it seems that everyone must see the justice of his reasoning.

We give praise, therefore, to your merits, O holy patriarch of the New Covenant, and we congratulate you on such great treasures. We bless God, who has shown himself so admirable in your sanctity. Be moved by our misery, and give us something from your abundance. As priests, some of us are privileged to bring onto the altar him whom you saw born in the stable and to receive into our hands and hearts him whom you carried in your arms. Make us, therefore, to share in your angelic purity that we may be less unworthy. Religious brothers and sisters, walking in your footsteps, vow themselves to a life of obedience, chastity, and poverty, that they may serve better and cause to be loved him whom you called on earth your adopted son. Obtain for them fidelity to their vows and perseverance in their vocation. Grant, also, that the young confided to our care may imitate your spotless purity and obedience so as to be distinguished always by pure morals, perfect docility to those directing them, and love for their duties. We ask this of you through the power of all those virtues we have just admired in you, and especially in the name of the glories that are their recompense. "Heart of Joseph, most pure and most faithful, pray for us."

The Glories of St. Joseph

The glories of St. Joseph are our next consideration. In the long genealogy written by St. Matthew and St. Luke to show that St. Joseph was of the most illustrious blood in the world and counted among his ancestors, patriarchs, prophets, heroes, and kings, we might find sufficient reason to attest his glory. We do not wish to seek therein, however, the titles to his glory. We would seek them, rather, in the prerogatives that faith reveals

in him by reason of his alliance with Mary, and this despite the obscurity of his life in Nazareth. Though in that poor retreat of Nazareth his was not the power with which David defied so many enemies of his country, though he was not clothed with the purple or surrounded with the pomp of Solomon, though the crown of Josaphat was not on his head nor the scepter of Judah in his hand, we can only believe that he was superior to all his illustrious ancestors by the fact that he merited to be the spouse of the queen of heaven and earth, the foster father of Jesus Christ, and the trustee of the authority of the eternal father over his incarnate Word.

Think on the unimaginable glory of St. Joseph in sharing the honors, the spiritual wealth, and all the sentiments of the mother of God. This ineffable privilege was given him by the Lord through his uniting Joseph in marriage to the mother of his own son. The result is that when the Church proclaims Mary queen of patriarchs, prophets, apostles, martyrs, confessors, and virgins, Joseph is as a king, sharing all these glorious titles. The Congregation of Rites, in deciding that the name of this great saint could always be added to the prayer *A cunctis*, permitted it to be placed before those of St. Peter and St. Paul, so certain is the Church of the greatness conferred on him by his function of spouse of the adopted daughter of the Most High, the mother of the Word made flesh, and the spouse of the Holy Spirit.³⁸ Though the apostles were, indeed, called to preach the Gospel, the martyrs to combat for the faith, the doctors to instruct the people, the pastors to govern, the confessors and the just to fill the world with the good odor of Jesus Christ, St. Joseph alone was destined to be the guardian of the whole economy of the mystery of the redemption. The adorable Trinity initiated him into the plan of the Incarnation, not only in confiding to him all the destinies of the holy Virgin, which constituted his first glory, but even in making him the foster father of the Savior.

Surely we cannot refuse him the title which the Gospel gives him, which Mary recognized in him, and with which the divine infant glorified him, the title of "father of Jesus." St. Luke tells us, "His father and mother were wondering at those things which were spoken concerning him" (Lk 2:33). Mary, on finding Jesus in the Temple, cried out, "Your father and I have sought you, sorrowing" (Lk 2:48). St. Bernardine of

Siena says in his beautiful panegyric: "Oh, what sweet melody to the ears of St. Joseph, when he heard the infant God lisp his name, call him father, hold out to him his little arms, and put them about his neck to embrace and caress him." Of this same matter, St. Basil says that all the angels and highest seraphim in heaven bear the name only of servants of God. Joseph alone of the whole Church militant and triumphant has the honor of bearing the name of father of the savior of humanity.

Not only did St. Joseph bear this glorious name; he fulfilled all its functions by clothing and feeding Jesus Christ through his labor, his weariness, and the sweat of his brow. Scarcely had the eternal father seen his only son under the form of a sinner when he abandoned him to the tender charity of St. Joseph. In the Savior's poverty and woe, St. Joseph accepted his guardianship, took care of his needs, showed him the affection of his heart, and fulfilled all the duties of a father toward him. It was Joseph who procured for Jesus the food that made his sacred body grow to its full strength and stature and that filled his veins with the precious blood which was shed for the salvation of the world. Thus, God the Father gave divinity to Jesus Christ, Mary furnished him his body, and our patron saint preserved his existence. We can but marvel at such a plan of cooperation and the everlasting glory it gave St. Joseph. He was only a man, and yet, by his daily toil, he earned the means to clothe, support, and even feed his God. One can conceive that the older Joseph was praised for saving Egypt in the time of famine, that Jacob was blessed by his father for once giving him food, that Abraham was rewarded for giving hospitality to three angels who entered his tent, that celestial spirits could congratulate themselves on being allowed to bring food to Jesus in the desert after his temptations. But what are these praises, blessings, and favors compared to the privilege of nourishing for almost thirty years the sovereign Lord of angels and of humans?

We read in the Gospel that at the end of the world our Lord will say to the elect on his right hand: "I was hungry, and you gave me to eat; I was thirsty, and you gave me to drink; I was a stranger, and you took me in; naked, and you covered me" (Mt 25:35-36). We can but imagine that all the predestined, turning their gaze on our holy patron, will avow that

needs of the child Jesus were the personal needs of his humanity and he actually received all these helps from his parents.

How happily did St. Joseph lavish his care on such a son! Think of his joy in having such a child for his own, to carry in his arms, to press against his heart, to cover with kisses, to protect as another guardian angel. I wish I could picture for you his loving transports, his sweet raptures, his delicious exaltations, his divine ecstasies in the midst of such privileges. Besides these dear intimacies so precious to his heart, he knew that he was really the delegate of the Holy Trinity, the virgin spouse of Mary, the foster father of the second person of the Trinity. To see the God, before whose throne they trembled as they adored, seated and eating at a poor table on earth between Mary and Joseph must have been a spectacle creating envy in the celestial court. One cannot even feebly conceive of those meals. One cannot begin to imagine the conversations that were the outward manifestation of the admirable accord, the ravishing union of hearts, in this visible and created trinity.

How your breast must have burned, O blessed father of my Savior, how fast your heart must have beat, and how living and intoxicating your emotions must have been when Jesus smiled at your paternal solicitude and rewarded it with new caresses. O Jesus, O Mary, O Joseph, little trinity of mutual lovers, what charms and pleasures were yours. No human words can ever express what passed in that house of Nazareth, which angels later carried into Italy, so as better to show the entire world the services that Mary and St. Joseph rendered in it to Jesus Christ.³⁹

The crowning glory to which our illustrious patron was elevated now breaks on our eyes with more radiance than the noonday sun. St. Joseph held on earth the delegated authority of the eternal father of his divine son, who respectfully obeyed Joseph and Mary. One dares to say that Jesus was even more obedient to Joseph than to Mary, since Mary, while commanding Jesus, obeyed Joseph as the head of the Holy Family. To help us understand more exactly the authority of this great patriarch over Jesus Christ, the Gospel tells us that Joseph was charged with naming the divine infant (Mt 1:21). Mark the thought that flows from this fact. God the Father produces the Word by his understanding, but

womb, but she gave him only the human nature. Joseph reproduced him entirely by his lips in naming him Jesus, since this sacred name includes both the divine and the human nature. See how Joseph appears again in this glorious privilege, as always, clothed with paternal power. To Joseph the angel pointed out the danger threatening the infant God from the jealousy of Herod; to him was given the command to take the child into Egypt; to him was indicated the time of the return to Nazareth; and for thirty years, his will served as the rule for the will of the Savior: "He was subject to them" (Lk 2:51).

Yes, it was principally our glorious patron who directed all the movements of Jesus Christ during his hidden life. In this regard, Joseph appears as the cherub who guided the triumphant chariot of Ezekiel (Ez 10:14-19), or better, as that angel who is charged with the sun, to direct his rising rays and withdraw his light seasonably. With infinite respect but also with all the authority of a father, Joseph, after seeking the divine will in sublime contemplation, would say to his adorable son, "Do this," and Jesus would do it. He would say, "Go there," and Jesus would go. "Work," and Jesus would work. "Rest," and Jesus would rest. Meanwhile, all the angels were in admiration of a God acting in blind obedience to a human being, to "the Lord obeying the voice of a human being" (Job 10:14). Though it was amazing in the time of King Hezekiah to have the sun put back ten degrees and stand still at the command of Joshua, it was not so much that a man commanded the sun as it was God who acceded to the prayer of Joshua.⁴⁰ Here, however, by a strange reversal, it was really the creature who was giving commands to the Creator. As God had to expiate by his obedience the disobedience of the human race, the Lord obeyed the voice of a human being. Could St. Joseph have been elevated to a more glorious dignity?

St. Augustine tells us that this mystery is represented by the astonishing dream of the older Joseph, who saw the sun, the moon, and the stars adoring him (Gn 37:9). He explains the matter as follows. Eleven stars adore, since the saints who are the bright stars of the firmament venerate the patriarch of the New Covenant as the father of their Savior. The moon adores him when Mary, figured by that queen of night, respects him as her spouse. The sun adores him when Jesus, the divine Sun of

Justice, obeys him as his father. Surely no one could refuse veneration to this great saint when he sees the master of heaven and earth, before whom all tremble and are as nothing, receive with docility the commands of this poor artisan and render him and Mary services that are humbling in themselves.

As for me, I fall at his feet. I am enraptured by such glory, and I willingly believe St. Joseph equal to the guardian angels. Did he not watch over the divine child committed to his care? I believe him equal to the archangels. Did he not communicate to Jesus and Mary the commands from heaven? I believe him equal to the virtues. Did he not govern the Holy Family? I believe him equal to the powers. Did he not manifest to the Egyptians the power of the Word made flesh, who would overthrow their idols? I believe him equal to the principalities and the dominions. Did he not command the king and queen of heaven? I believe him equal to the thrones. Did he not carry Jesus in his arms? I believe him equal to the cherubim. Did he not penetrate the deepest mysteries of wisdom incarnate? I believe him equal to the seraphim. Was he not raised on wings of fire to the heights of contemplation and did he not love Jesus Christ with a love so burning that, like the love of these blessed spirits, it transformed him, as St. Bernard says?

This supernatural transformation made St. Joseph worthy to be one of the visible trinity that the house of Nazareth sheltered. In this trinity, Mary held the place of God the Father, since she became the mother of the Savior just as he is the Savior's father. Jesus kept his rank in this trinity of earth, between Mary and Joseph, as between the Father and the Holy Spirit in the Trinity of heaven. St. Joseph held the place of the Holy Spirit, being the love of the mother and the infant God, as the Holy Spirit is the love of the Father and the Son. These three persons, who represent so visibly the invisible Trinity, represent also the unity of God, for the three of them have morally but one heart and one soul.

Do you think, my dearly beloved, that God could have elevated St. Joseph to a higher degree of glory and crowned him with greater honor? What may have been said in the conversations of this adorable family, what were the thoughts that enlightened their minds, the sentiments that animated their hearts—this is not given us to understand or even to know.

I can say only that I think the whole celestial court was attentive to this ravishing spectacle of heavenly love and listened devoutly to the conversations of Jesus, Mary, and Joseph.

What more can we add to make clear the glorious privileges of St. Joseph? Let us conclude with that happy and unique privilege of our illustrious patron, the one that makes him the universally recognized patron of a happy death. St. Joseph had the unimaginable privilege of dying with Jesus and Mary close by his deathbed to assist him in his last moments. These two, in gratitude for the tireless services he had given them with such loving zeal, now gave him theirs, vying in tender care to lavish on him the aids of a divine tenderness. Surely in this supreme moment, troops of angels came to make St. Joseph's blessed dying joyful with their songs.

St. Bernardine of Siena says he does not know how to express the consolations, the sweetness, the lights, the tender emotions, and the flames of love that moved this soul, blessed above all souls, in its passage to eternity. Undoubtedly, Jesus held one of his arms beneath the weary head and the other he placed on that heart on which he had so often rested in his infancy, piercing it with the darts of his charity as he treasured its every beat. Therefore, the Church compares the death of St. Joseph sometimes to a peaceful sleep, such as that of a child on its mother's breast, and sometimes to an aromatic torch that in dying breathes out an ever-sweeter odor.

After considering all these privileges, one readily admits the opinion of those who think that this great saint rose with Jesus Christ, for he was dead at least three years before the passion of the Savior. St. Bernardine of Siena, preaching at Padua, authorized this pious belief by crying out before a great audience: "I assure you that St. Joseph is body and soul in heaven, shining with glory." Fact added confirmation to this belief, for there appeared immediately above the head of the celebrated speaker a miraculous cross of gold, which was seen by all the listeners.⁴¹

However this came to be, we can now very easily imagine this glorious patriarch in the height of heaven above all the saints and angels. For so many virtues and privileges on earth, for so many services rendered to the mother of God and the son of the Most Holy Trinity.

St. Augustine says, be placed immediately after Mary and very close to Jesus. It is indeed fitting that the Holy Family be in paradise as it was on earth. Who could dare to separate in eternity what grace so tightly bound in time? We must definitely conclude, from all we have just meditated, that he whom we honor, having been during his life the greatest of saints, is also in heaven the most elevated in glory after Jesus and Mary.

The New Joseph

Let us go, then, to the new Joseph. Oh, let us give him the homage of a sincere devotion. We cannot refuse this honor when we see him honored by angels, by the queen of virgins, by Jesus Christ himself, and by the whole Church, which proclaims him the protector of Christians in general, and in particular of religious orders. We can but run to his protection when we hear St. Teresa of Avila assure us that she never invoked him without being heard immediately. She put under his protection the first monastery of her reform, saying that since Jesus Christ had refused him nothing during the time he submitted to him on earth, he will refuse him even less now that he reigns with him in glory. Should one not, therefore, see all Christians at his feet, glorifying him by their devotion?

Let us cast ourselves into his arms, then, as in olden times the children of Jacob cast themselves into the arms of their brother. Just as the older Joseph comforted them in their needs and loaded them with gifts, the new Joseph will care for us (Gn 42:1-45:25). "Go to Joseph, and do all that he shall say to you" (Gn 41:55). Alas, like the Egyptians of that time, we have had also our years of abundance and growth, happy years which scarcely passed the number seven. During this time we amassed treasures of virtue; but without foresight and wisdom, we have perhaps dissipated our spiritual wealth, lost all our merits. Now our soul, sterile and dry, is a prey to scarcity or even famine. Let us cry for mercy to St. Joseph, and he will open the granaries of grace to enrich us.

"O chaste spouse of the Virgin and foster father of my Savior, you open your ears to all who implore your assistance, and so from this

moment, I invoke you with new confidence for the priests, brothers, and sisters who have the honor of belonging to a community of which you are the powerful protector. I implore you also for the young whose minds we are charged to develop and whose hearts we are to form. Can you be deaf to my prayer when its end is to make us more worthy of you, your divine son, and our own sublime destiny? Ah, I beg you in the name of your celestial spouse, who is our mother, and through the love of your adorable son for our souls, hear our prayers on this day consecrated to your memory. Hear especially the prayer I address you and shall often repeat: to show yourself always my defender and my father, and when the moment of my death comes, when my soul, about to quit my body, will pour out its last sigh, O Joseph, show yourself to it as its advocate before its judge, and refresh my dying eyes with your dear presence. Amen."